

Urocitellus columbianus

Columbian ground squirrel



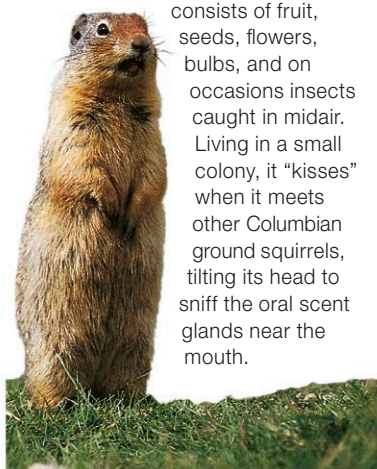
Length 9³/₂–10 in (24.7–25.8 cm)
Tail 3¹/₄–4 in (8.4–10 cm)
Weight 15¹/₂–17¹/₁₆ oz (441–490 g)

Location W. Canada to N.W. USA

Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The Columbian ground squirrel (“Columbia” being British Columbia, Canada) comes from mountain meadows and hilly grassland. Its diet



consists of fruit, seeds, flowers, bulbs, and on occasions insects caught in midair. Living in a small colony, it “kisses” when it meets other Columbian ground squirrels, tilting its head to sniff the oral scent glands near the mouth.

Cynomys ludovicianus

Black-tailed prairie dog



Length 14¹/₂ in (37.3 cm)
Tail 3¹/₄–3¹/₂ in (8.4–8.7 cm)
Weight 29¹/₁₆–32 oz (819–905 g)

Location S.W. Canada to N. Mexico

Social unit Group
Status Least concern



Preference for a grassy habitat and a barklike, doggy “yip” give 5 species of ground squirrels their common name of prairie dogs. The black-tailed or plains prairie dog dwells at altitudes of 4,300–6,600 ft (1,300–2,000 m) across the Great Plains of North America and south into the more arid, extreme north of Mexico. The body hairs of the black-tailed prairie dog are tipped black in winter but white in summer, and the whiskers and end third of the tail are black. This rodent eats a range of seasonal plants, such as wheat grass, buffalo grass, globe mallow, and rabbit brush in summer, and thistles, cacti such as prickly pear, and underground roots and bulbs in winter. Prairie dogs breed rapidly, with up to 8 young born after a gestation period of 34–35 days. In the past, their feeding habits led to massive destruction of wheat and other cereal

crops, and their burrows tripped horses and farm stock. As a result, prairie dogs were subject to extermination campaigns, which were very successful. In recent times, the rodents have been restricted mainly to parks and reserves. Their drastic reduction in numbers has seriously threatened the black-footed ferret (see p.190), for which they were virtually sole prey.



COTERIES AND WARD



The basic prairie dog social unit is the coterie of one male, several females, and their young. Several coterie form a ward, members guarding their territories and burrows with an energetic “jump-yip” display, bared chattering teeth, and fluffed-up tails. Many ward form a township of up to 160 acres (65 hectares).

COLORATION

The black-tailed prairie dog is generally brown or reddish brown on the upperparts, shading to white on the underparts. The whiskers and tail tip are black.

small eyes

Geosciurus inauris

South African ground squirrel



Length 8–12 in (20–30 cm)
Tail 7¹/₂–8¹/₂ in (19.4–21 cm)
Weight 15–23 oz (423–649 g)

Location Southern Africa

Social unit Group
Status Least concern



The large claws of the South African ground squirrel can burrow in hard, dry, stony soil. The upper fur is brownish pink with a white flank stripe and belly. The prominent eyes are circled with white and the muzzle and feet are also white. There are black bands near the base and tip of the tail. Its diet is opportunistic, ranging from seeds, bulbs, and roots to insects and birds’ eggs. This ground squirrel lives in colonies of 6–10, and in some cases up to 30.



Heliosciurus gambianus

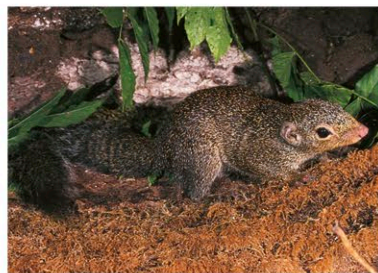
Gambian sun squirrel



Length 6–8¹/₂ in (15.5–21 cm)
Tail 6–12 in (15.5–30 cm)
Weight 9–13 oz (250–350 g)

Location Africa

Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



Banded hairs in yellows, browns, and grays give the sun squirrel a speckled olive-brown appearance. The tail has 14 rings along its length and the eyes are white ringed. In habit, this squirrel is a typical ground-and-tree species, with a diet ranging from seeds to birds’ eggs. Its distinctive behaviors include “basking” on sunny branches, as its name suggests, and relining its nest each night with freshly plucked leaves.

Ratufa indica

Indian giant squirrel



Length 13¹/₂–18 in (35–45 cm)
Tail 15–19¹/₂ in (38–49 cm)
Weight 2–5¹/₂ lb (0.9–2.3 kg)

Location C. and S. India

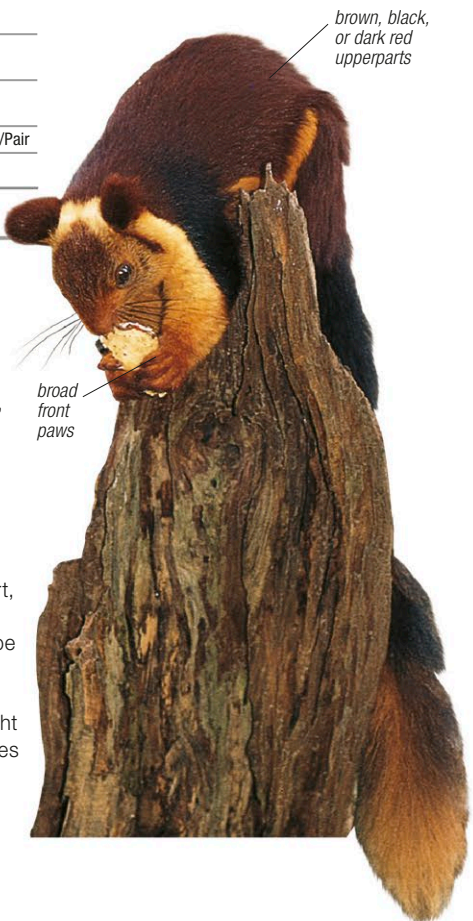
Social unit Individual/Pair
Status Least concern



The huge, bushy tail of the Indian giant squirrel is usually longer than the head and body combined. The upperparts are dark, the head and limbs red-brown, and the underside whitish. This squirrel, alert and wary, makes massive leaps of 20 ft (6 m) among branches as it forages for fruit, nuts, bark, insects, and eggs. Its characteristic feeding posture is not upright but leaning forward or down, perched on its back legs with the tail as a counterbalance. Its short, broad thumbs help it to manipulate food. It builds the typical squirrel-type nest (drey) for resting and rearing young. Reproduction in this species is not well known but they are thought to breed throughout the year. Females usually produce 1–2 offspring in each litter after a gestation period of 28–35 days.

FEEDING POSITION

This squirrel shows the typical feeding posture of this species. Its long tail provides stability while it eats its food, which is skillfully manipulated by dexterous front paws.



brown, black, or dark red upperparts

broad front paws